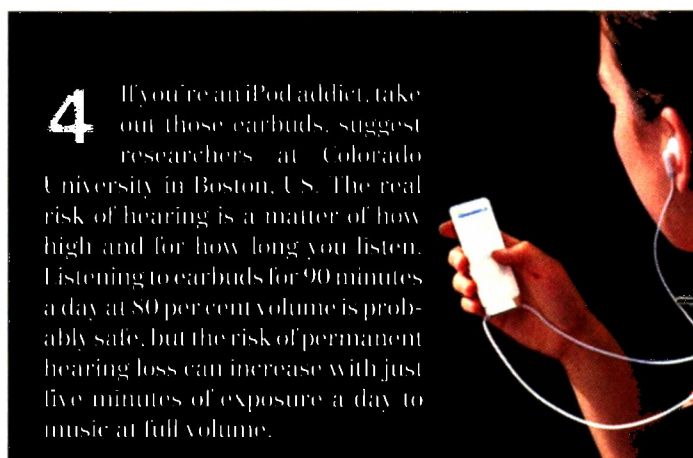


Sickness in a WIRED WORLD

As India fast-tracks to the digital era, new age health problems are spiralling up



Computers make your eyes shift and focus between the screen, document and keyboard 25,000 times a day, the equivalent of 60 push-ups a minute. No wonder that CVS—a syndrome denoting irritable, dry, red, painful eyes—is doing the rounds. For relief, place the monitor 30 inches away; adjust the screen at about 10 to 20 degrees below horizontal line of sight; tilt it up as if it were a book (tear evaporation is less this way). Follow the 20-20-20 rule: every 20 minutes, take a 20-second break and focus 20 ft away.



4 If you're an iPod addict, take out those earbuds, suggest researchers at Colorado University in Boston, US. The real risk of hearing is a matter of how high and for how long you listen. Listening to earbuds for 90 minutes a day at 80 per cent volume is probably safe, but the risk of permanent hearing loss can increase with just five minutes of exposure a day to music at full volume.

CELLPHONE ELBOW

Too much yakking on a cellphone causes this new syndrome, also called cubital tunnel syndrome. Prolonged flexing of the elbow puts tension on the ulnar nerve running along the elbow, causing numbness, tingling and pain in the forearm. It can make writing and typing difficult. Use a hands-free set with your cellphone.

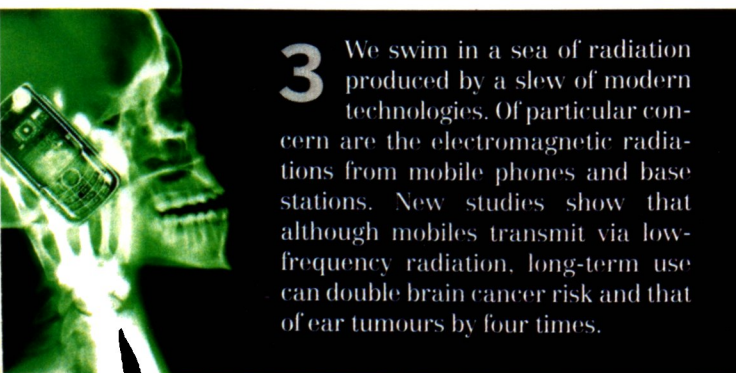


REPETITIVE STRAIN INJURY



It occurs when tendons, muscles, nerves and other soft tissues in hands and shoulders get strained due to prolonged use of computers. Stiffness, tingling and sore arms are a sure sign. Take regular breaks to stretch and massage arms and shoulders; position desks and chairs at the right height to prevent the pain that comes with RSI.

ELECTROMAGNETIC RADIATION



3 We swim in a sea of radiation produced by a slew of modern technologies. Of particular concern are the electromagnetic radiations from mobile phones and base stations. New studies show that although mobiles transmit via low-frequency radiation, long-term use can double brain cancer risk and that of ear tumours by four times.



SICK BUILDING SYNDROME

Spending the bulk of your day at office may result in SBS—headaches, itchy eyes, skin rashes, nasal allergy, throat irritation, dizziness, aches and pain. Caused by faulty ventilation, air-conditioning systems, organic compound emissions from building materials and contaminants, a houseplant is the answer to SBS.

■ Compiled by **Damayanti Datta**